



Close quarters: From Under-19 to Team India, Dravid has had a front-row view of Yashasvi Jaiswal's rise in Indian cricket. K. MURALI KUMAR

clear about this. A key part of Rajasthan Royals' ethos is to grow cricketers, but also to grow people — not just within cricket but across the organisation. It's deeply embedded in our DNA.

That's something we'd like to believe differentiates us from some other franchises. Of course, other teams are also trying to do the same, which is great for the league. But it remains an important part of the Royals' philosophy, reflected in the players we choose to retain.

You have been associated with the national setup for a long time, first with NCA and then the national team? How does your role at a franchise vary from those?

Some aspects of a franchise team are slightly different, which is natural. In a franchise, your connection with the players is much shorter — just about two months.

Of course, we do hold camps and maintain some level of contact throughout the year. But there are also additional responsibilities



As India head coach

2024 T20 World Cup win
2023 ODI World Cup finalist
2023 Asia Cup win
2022 T20 World Cup semifinalist
2023 World Test Championship (WTC) finalist

beyond cricket. As a head coach, you interact more with ownership and work closely with the sports science team.

That said, coaching teams, at their core, function similarly. It's always about working with people — the players and support staff.

The main difference is in the structure and timeframe. With the national team or at the NCA, you have more time to develop players and build long-term connections. The focus isn't on just one tournament.

In the IPL, however, your primary goal is to get the best out of your squad in a short, intense period and put the team in the best position to win the league.

You've nurtured talents like Parag and Yashasvi Jaiswal at the U-19 and NCA level. How different was it managing them as a coach in the senior team or in an IPL set up, as compared to their junior days?

It's terrific to see these youngsters grow into full-fledged professionals and even senior players within their teams.

That growth is exactly what you look for as a coach of a junior or Under-19 team. You want to see how the players you've worked with evolve — not just in their game but also as individuals.

Naturally, the conversations you have with them now are very different from when they were 16 or 17. As a coach, you must adapt to their growth.

At the U-19 level, you often take on a more instructional role, guiding them closely. But at this stage, they are experienced professionals. Your role shifts from instructing to supporting. As a coach, you